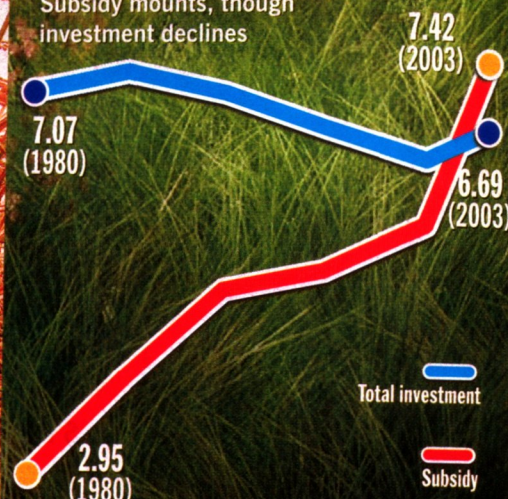


LOW YIELDS: Grain production has remained stagnant

A PRABHAKAR RAO

RISING SUBSIDIES

Subsidy mounts, though investment declines



THE CRISIS

- No new technological breakthrough in terms of high-yielding varieties for foodgrain crops
- Soil fatigue due to over-exploitation of nutrients and organic matter in intensive cropping areas
- Nutrient imbalance due to use of improper combination of fertilisers
- Non-availability of quality seeds resulting in low seed replacement rates
- Inadequate or poor harvest management infrastructure at the farm level

THE CONTROL

- Some promising candidates for pulses and rice should be pushed through rapidly
- Crop rotation and replenishment of micro-nutrients to help restore fertility
- Optimal use of fertilisers with the right NPK mix, without overdose of nitrogenous nutrient
- Development of market and infrastructure for making seeds available to farmers
- Making institutional credit available to farmers so they can make use of improved technology

Rs 25,000 cr is the additional central assistance to states.

commodities like tea crossing Rs 49,802 crore, the balance is still in India's favour as far as agricultural products are concerned.

Meanwhile, in an effort to boost yields in some of these crops, farmers have overused fertilisers or mixed them in the wrong proportion. Since urea is cheaper than potash or phosphorous, farmers have grossly misused it, damaging the fertility of the soil.

"There is no room for flexibility anymore in Indian agriculture; the era of self-sufficiency is over," warns Hardeep Singh, chairman of both Amalgamated Plantations (formerly Tata Tea) and the CII's national committee on agriculture marketing and infrastructure. Singh points out that any attempt to increase the production of oilseed or pulses

would be at the expense of wheat and rice crops. To grow an additional two million tonne of pulses, we would have to give up 8 million tonne of rice. To stave off five million tonne of oil imports, we would need an acreage capable of growing 30 million tonne of foodgrain.

In response to the crisis, the Government is now focusing on what Ahluwalia terms "bridging the yield gap". He points out that in wheat, while Punjab has reached near-maximum yields, Madhya Pradesh has achieved only 16 per cent of the total potential. Similarly, rice yields in Assam and Bihar are still extremely low and can be easily boosted. So the idea is to pump in investments to build infrastructure and supply all the vital agricultural inputs to boost productivity in these areas. The prime minister has also announced a massive Rs 25,000-crore sum as additional central assistance to states to help agriculture come up with district-level strategies that can boost production.

A food security mission has been set up to meet the expected increase in foodgrain demand of 20 million tonne in the next four years. The Government has set an ambitious target of boosting agricultural growth from the cur-



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HARDEEP SINGH, CHAIRMAN, AMALGAMATED PLANTATIONS